My Kid Isn’t Bad

Understanding What Your Teen Is Really Saying

6th–12th Grade Parent Education Workshop

Scan for materials
Passcode: Empathy26

SESSION 1: ONLINE VIA ZOOM

Monday, Sept 14 · 6:00 – 8:00 PM
Zoom Meeting · Class Code: 16649

SESSION 2: ABRAXAS HIGH SCHOOL

Monday, Nov 2 · 6:00 – 8:00 PM
In-Person · Class Code: 16587

Gradient Resolutions · Mediator Laura · GradientResolutions.com

WHY THIS WORK

From the Classroom to the Mediation Table

After law school, when my daughter was born, I stepped away from mediation to spend time with her — and somewhere in that time off, I fell in love with her preschool.

I ended up teaching there for six years, eventually becoming a Master Infant-Toddler teacher, working alongside parents as they balanced work, family, and the whole messy process of becoming parents themselves.

When I came back to mediation, I brought all of that child development and family education with me. Now, my work is about helping families build co-parenting plans that actually fit their family — not a generic template, but something customized to who your kids actually are and what they actually need.

I believe this season of transition can also be a real opportunity — and I'm privileged to walk that path alongside families, every day.



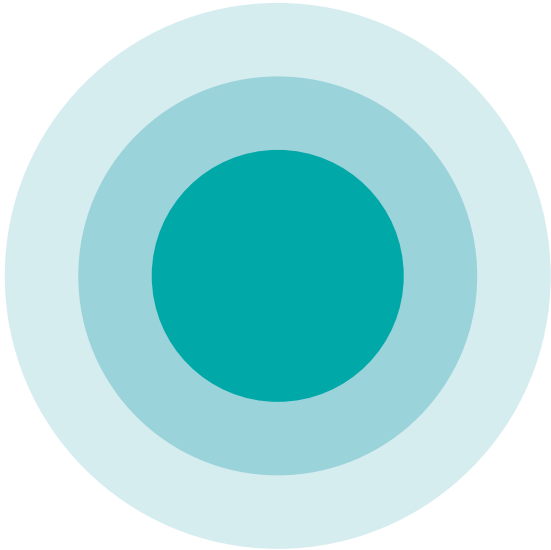
WORKSHOP OPENING · HOPE CHECK-IN

How many of you are here because you still have hope?

Hope isn't a feeling we wait for. It's built, step by step, with a plan.

Show of hands.

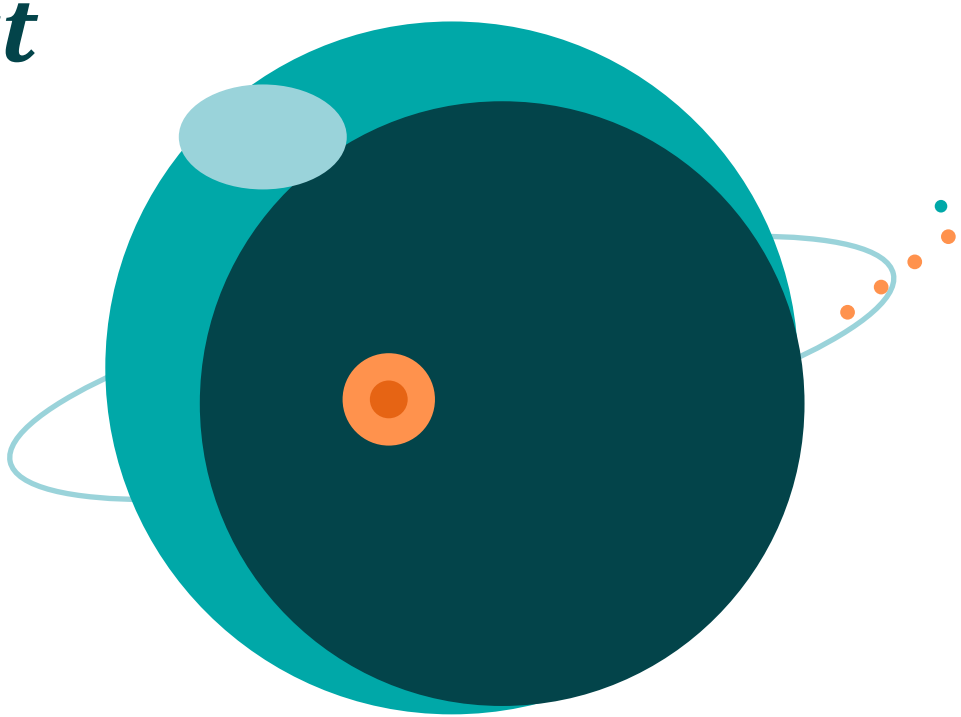
Online? Type "hope" in the chat.



A GOAL, A PLAN, A WISH

“A goal without a plan is just a wish.”

— Common saying, author unknown



Here, the goal is hope.

Hope gets real when you can name the next step.

WORKSHOP FRAMING

Welcome & Intention Setting

QUESTION 1

What are you hoping to gain tonight?

QUESTION 2

What do you need to leave behind so you can be fully present?

WHY YOU'RE HERE TONIGHT

Shift Your Role: Moving From Field Player to Sideline Coach

Why Most Parents Register

- School refusal or morning battles
- Pushing back on every boundary
- Conversations that shut down instantly
- Feeling like a stranger in your own home

THE CORE THESIS

By 18, your child needs to have already practiced the skills they need to navigate life on their own.

THE SIDELINE COACH METAPHOR:

✓ NOT playing on the field — doing everything for them and managing every detail.

✓ NOT in the parking lot on your phone — checked out or emotionally unavailable.

✓ ON THE SIDELINE — present, watching closely, and stepping in at specific timeout moments.



FOUNDATION · THE POSITIVE COLUMN

Building the Positive Column

Positive childhood experiences are linked to better adult mental health, even for kids who faced adversity.

72%

lower odds of adult depression or 14+ poor mental health days: 6–7 PCEs vs. 0–2

50%

lower odds with 3–5 PCEs vs. 0–2

The seven positive childhood experiences

1. Able to talk with family about feelings
2. Family stood by them during difficult times
3. Felt safe and protected by an adult at home
4. At least two non-parent adults took a genuine interest
5. Felt supported by friends
6. Felt a sense of belonging in high school
7. Enjoyed participating in community traditions

Note: the study is cross-sectional and relies on adult recall. It shows association, not cause.

Source: Bethell et al., JAMA Pediatrics, 2019 · Mediator Laura · GradientResolutions.com

PART 1

The Developmental Case: Why This Age, Why Now

The pulling-away isn’t a personality flaw or a parenting failure. It’s developmentally designed.
This is training season, not the championship.

The Highest-Risk Years

- The tween/teen years are the years of highest risk — this is when kids are most likely to get hooked on drugs, alcohol, or cigarettes, if they're going to at all.
- Everything in their developing bodies is telling them to pull away and assert themselves — which is exactly why it feels hardest on parents right now, and exactly why it is often the hardest developmental stage to parent through.
- **A coach who prevents every mistake in practice produces a player who falls apart in the real game.**
- Worth a brief mention: dating norms and sex ed are arriving on this same accelerated clock — often before a parent feels ready.

It’s Not an Emergency — It’s a Role Mismatch

- Pushing back on everything and shutting down conversation is, itself, pretty normal — for some kids it’s mostly a middle-school-years thing; for others it cycles up and down across the whole developmental window.

- The reason it feels unbearable is usually that **you’re playing the wrong role for this moment** — still cast as the organizing, problem-solving parent, when this age calls for the coach on the sideline.

- Most of what feels like an emergency is really a role mismatch, not a crisis.

PART 1 · THE DEVELOPMENTAL CASE

Why Teen Push-Off Can Feel So Ugly and Personal

1. THE INTERNAL STRUGGLE

To separate and build their own identity, teens have to convince themselves to push off from you.

2. THE HARSH OUTWARD EXPRESSION

That internal friction often comes out as rude behavior, sharp words, or outright rejection. It feels deeply personal.

3. NAMING IT IS PROTECTIVE

Expecting this behavior protects your heart. It shifts the moment from an emotional crisis into expected developmental progress.

When It's More Than Normal Pushback: The Triage Path

QUALITATIVE WARNING SIGNALS (Role shift from Coach → Investigator):

Refusing to go to school · Not coming home at night · Total withdrawal from safety networks

STEP 1: PEDIATRICIAN

Always start here.

Rule out underlying medical issues, sleep disorders, or physical health concerns before jumping to behavioral conclusions.

STEP 2A: THERAPIST

If Anxiety / Depression is present.

Provides a safe, non-judgmental space to process root causes and emotional distress before negotiating plans.

STEP 2B: MEDIATOR

If Anxiety / Depression ruled out, or being addressed separately (e.g. already in therapy).

Helps parent and teen build a collaborative plan forward. Teens crave being consulted and making their own decisions.

PART 1 · REFLECTION

Reflection Moment: Re-Framing the Distance

TAKE A MOMENT TO CONSIDER:

Think of one specific area where your teen has pulled away from you recently.

What if that pulling-away was actually on schedule — rather than them being mean or ungrateful?

Turn to the person next to you and discuss. (Or share with the room).

PART 2

Releasing Control,
Staying the Person They Turn To

It’s no longer your job to control what they do, who they’re with, or how they handle things.
Your job is to be the safe harbor they come back to.

PART 2 · RELEASING CONTROL

The Romeo & Juliet Problem: Resist Fixing Mid-Play

THE LESSON FROM THE TRAGEDY:

The real tragedy of Romeo & Juliet is the frantic pace — everything spins out of control faster and faster, and no adult ever steps in calmly to slow it down.

- Resist the urge to solve, punish, or advise mid-drama when emotions are peaked.
- A coach does NOT run onto the field mid-play to correct footwork — that happens at the timeout.
- Boundaries, rules, and life stories have immense value, but ONLY when delivered outside the emotional moment.

A Generation of Snowplow Parents

- "Snowplow parenting" (popularized via *The New York Times*, distinct from helicopter parenting): clearing obstacles out of a child's path *before* they become a problem, rather than swooping in after.

- Researchers call the broader pattern "overparenting" or "intensive parenting" — snowplow is just today's word for it. The data is real: overparenting is linked to loneliness, social anxiety, and difficulty regulating emotions once kids are on their own (Jiao et al., 2023).

- It's most prevalent among families combining high achievement standards with high safety/developmental anxiety — exactly the pressure many of us are navigating.

- We know what's coming, and we try to smooth it out before our child has the chance to gain the exact experience they need to build resilience.

PART 2 · RELEASING CONTROL

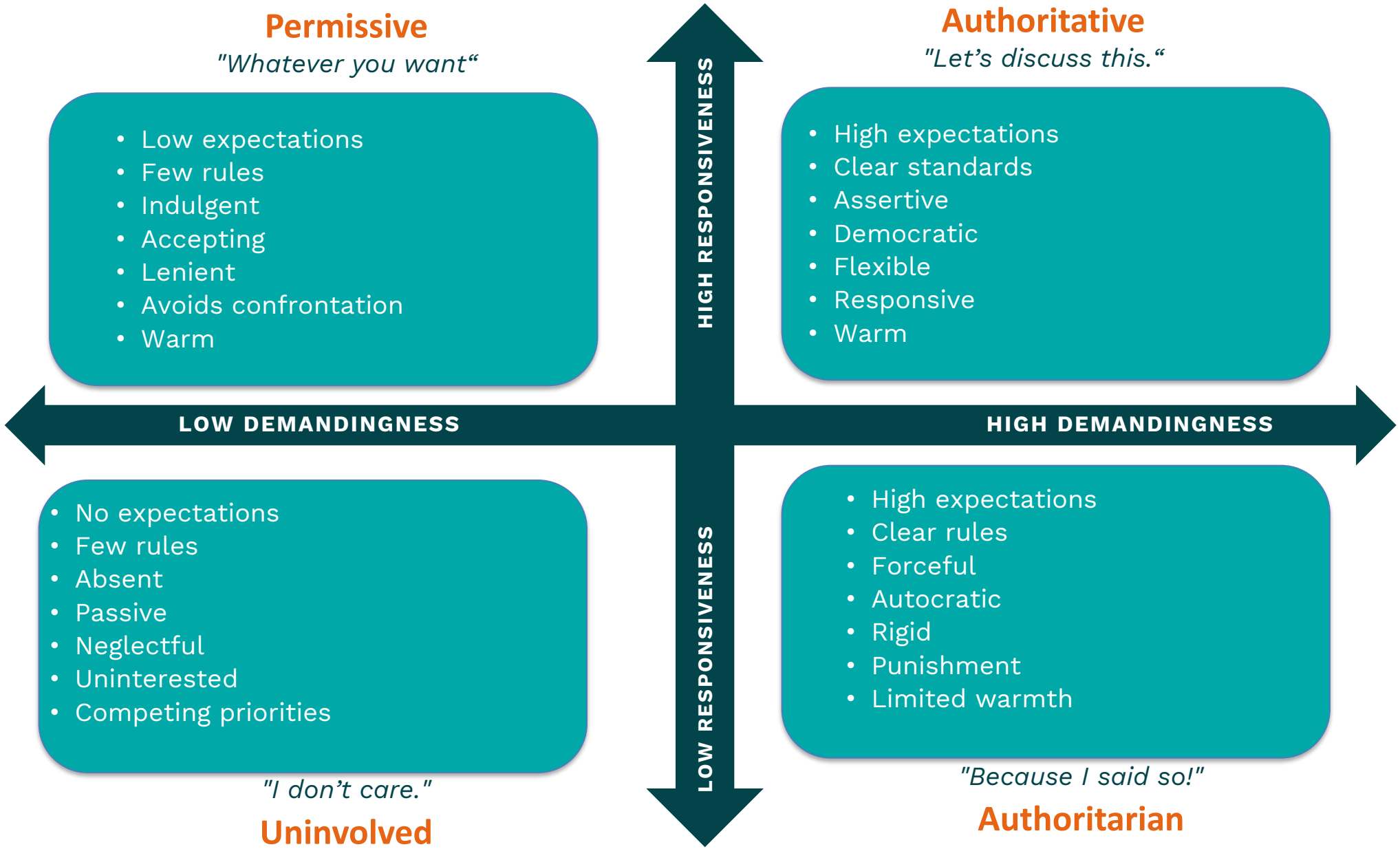
Trading Direct Control for Vulnerability Builds Real Trust

MEL ROBBINS — 'LET THEM'

- Stop forcing compliance with their choices, friendships, or problem-solving.
- Controlling directly pushes them away rather than keeping them safe.
- Let them handle their choices, and let yourself off the hook from managing every outcome.

BRENÉ BROWN — VULNERABILITY

- When you stop controlling outcomes, you aren't required to have all the answers.
- Unsolicited advice invites instant resistance from a teen.
- Saying 'I didn't see that coming either — let's figure out the next play together' builds lasting trust.


Permissive
"Whatever you want"
Low expectations
Few rules
Indulgent
Accepting
Lenient
Avoids confrontation
Warm
Authoritative
"Let's discuss this."
High expectations
Clear standards
Assertive
Democratic
Flexible
Responsive
Warm
HIGH RESPONSIVENESS
LOW DEMANDINGNESS
HIGH DEMANDINGNESS
LOW RESPONSIVENESS
No expectations
Few rules
Absent
Passive
Neglectful
Uninterested
Competing priorities
"I don't care."
Uninvolved
High expectations
Clear rules
Forceful
Autocratic
Rigid
Punishment
Limited warmth
"Because I said so!"
Authoritarian

Name the Win: They Turn to You When They Struggle

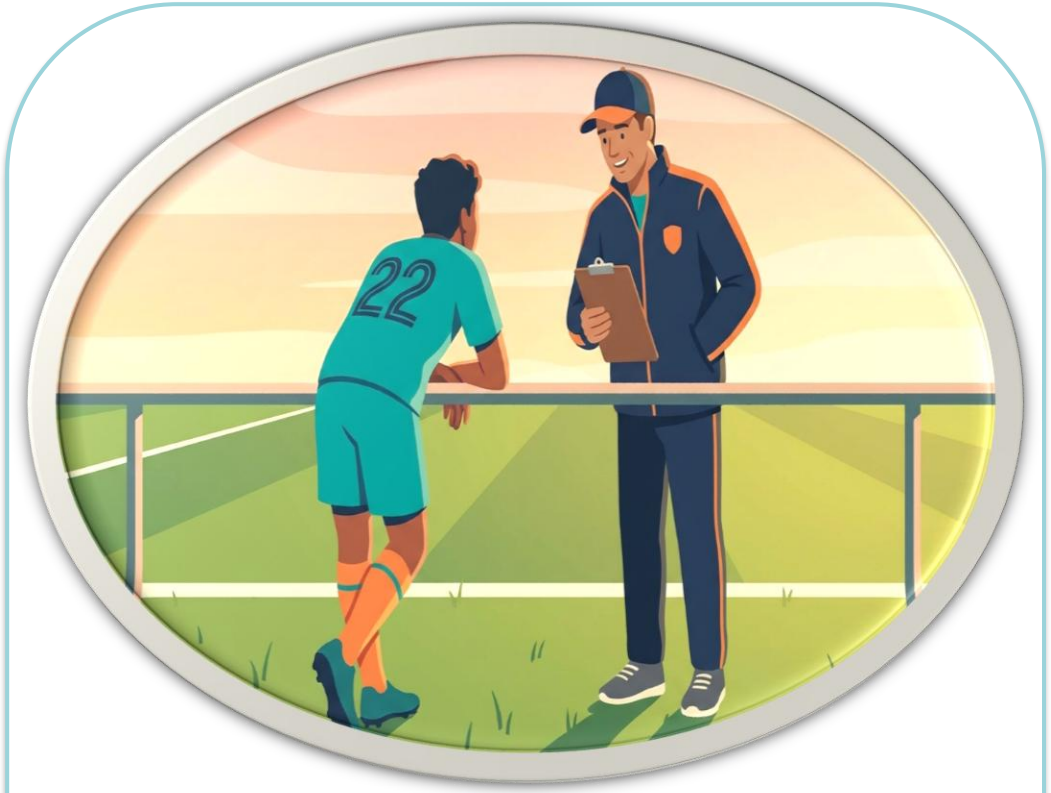
RE-DEFINING SUCCESS IN TEEN PARENTING

The win is NOT that your teen never struggles, gets into trouble, or takes risks.

The win is that when they are in it, they turn to you.

- The Sideline Metaphor: Think of an athlete coming to the sideline for water between plays — they get what they need, recalibrate, and head back out onto the field confident.

- Practical Goal: Move from being an active field player trying to control every move to a trusted, accessible coach on the bench.



Sideline Coaching in Action

Creating a trusted space for guidance between plays

AAP Signals: Identifying Consistent Patterns vs. Bad Days

Sleep & Appetite Shifts

Noticeable changes in sleep patterns, weight, or eating habits.

Loss of Interest

Dropping activities, sports, or hobbies they usually love.

Social Withdrawal

Withdrawing significantly more than usual from family and friends.

Unexplained Cancellations

Canceling plans with close friends without a clear explanation.

Academic Struggles

Uncharacteristic academic decline or intense school anxiety.

New Friend Group

An entirely new group of friends you haven't met or heard about.

Note: One symptom alone is an invitation to pay attention — a consistent pattern is the signal.

Feelings Before Facts: The AAP Communication Model

INSTEAD OF THIS... (Accusation)

“You’ve been acting really strange these past few weeks. What is going on?”

- Leads with accusation and fact-finding.
- Reads to a teen as an inquisition.
- Causes defenses to go up instantly.

TRY THIS... (Observation + Feeling)

“I noticed you haven’t wanted to come to dinner lately. I wondered if something is making it hard to enjoy things you love.”

- Leads with neutral observation and warmth.
- Invites connection without judgment.
- Facts emerge naturally once defenses drop.

PART 3

The Coaching Skill: How You Actually Do This

Before any technique works, you have to regulate yourself first. You don't coach during the play; you coach in the huddle.

REGULATE YOURSELF FIRST

The 60-Second Reset

Before you worry about what to say to your kids, check in with what your body is already saying for you.

1. **Feel your feet on the floor.**
   A simple, physical anchor to the present moment.

2. **Take one or two slow, deliberate breaths.**
   Not a fix — just enough to interrupt the cycle.

3. **Look around. Name three different colors you see.**
   Moves you out of your emotions and into your intellect.

4. **Unclench your jaw. Drop your shoulders.**
   A small physical reset before you walk in.

This is a pattern interrupt, not a fix. Recovery takes time and consistency — one good reset won't undo months of tension. It interrupts today's moment.

Harvey Karp's Fast-Food Rule

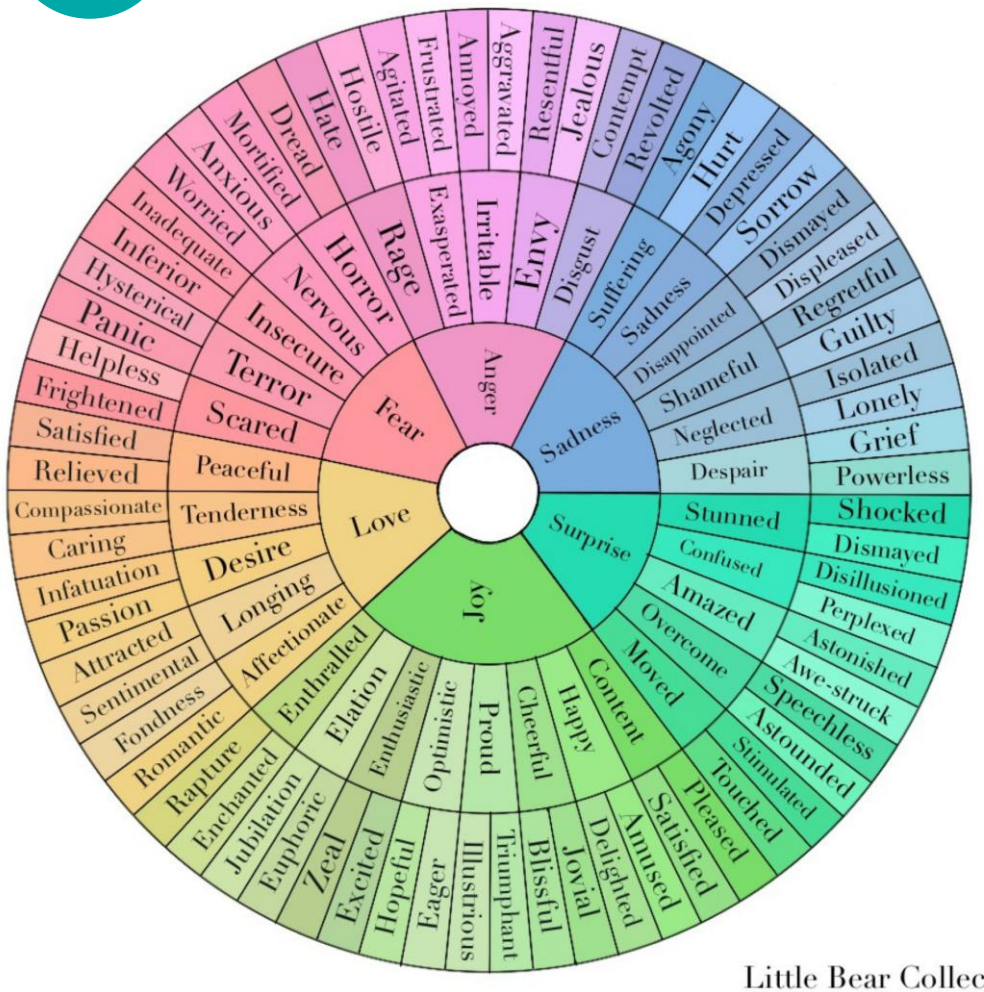
- **Reflect the feeling back in short, simple phrases** — *before* offering reasoning or advice.

- **The win here is to get them talking.** Correcting them or advising them is likely to just shut them down.

- For example: **"That sounds really frustrating"** — not "Well, what did you expect?"

- **Short and simple beats thorough and articulate**. You're proving you heard them, not writing an essay.

The Emotion Wheel



Little Bear Collective
The Junto Institute

- The vocabulary that makes the reflect-back specific, instead of defaulting to “mad” or “fine.”

- The goal: Get them out of their emotions and into their thinking/problem-solving brain.

- Even if they call it stupid or resist it — keep it out and around. Use it yourself, out loud, and talk about what you’re finding. They’ll pick up the skill by watching, whether or not they touch it themselves.

Talk in Front of Them, Not to Them



- Karp's technique for lower-pressure absorption of "I see you" — without the confrontation of direct eye contact and a pointed question.

Be the carpool parent, the house the friend group hangs out at — join the "tea" about their friends, and you become the parent other kids turn to, which eventually brings your own teen to you too.

Empathize — Don’t Solve

Conversations that turn into lectures or fix-it sessions train a teen to stop initiating them.

In Love While Parenting app: short lectures and demonstration videos

https://www.humanimprovement.org/the-in-love-while-parenting-app

Exercise: Live Role-Play

SCENARIO: THE ESCALATION

1. SET BOUNDARY
Friday night, I told my son he couldn't go to his friend's after the game because we already had family dinner planned.

2. REACTION
He didn't just get annoyed — he came right at me:

3. OUTBURST
"You never let me do anything, everyone else's parents are cool, I hate this family!" [Door slammed]

4. PARENT REACTION
I just stood there in the hallway, stunned.

THE COACH'S RESPONSE

If you are the parent, send a text after you've caught your breath (using the 60-Second Reset):

RECOMMENDED TEXT MESSAGE:

“Wow, I can see you are really upset. I’m here to listen when you are ready to talk.”

WHY THIS WORKS:
Acknowledges the emotion without taking the bait or entering an argument. Keeps the doorway open for when they regulate.

Roleplay: When Your Teen Misses Curfew

SCENARIO: Your teen comes home past curfew without texting or calling to let you know.

STEP 1

Express Worry Without Emotion

• State your feeling plainly: "I was worried about you when you didn't text."
• Ask what happened calmly, without yelling or interrogation.
• Keep your emotional charge out of the initial exchange.

STEP 2

Offer Two Choices on Timing

• Pause the heat: Let them know you will discuss this soon when everyone is calm.
• Give concrete options: "Do you want to discuss it after dinner tomorrow, or this weekend?"
• Keeps the conversation from evaporating while giving them agency.

STEP 3

Set Clear Intentions for Rules

• Set clear goals for the meeting: "We need to get clear on what to do if this happens again."
• Frame the goal as alignment on rules and consequences, not punishment.
• Prepares both of you to enter mediation mode.

KEY PRINCIPLE: Empathy and calm boundary-setting in the moment earn the right to negotiate effective rules later.

After You've Empathized: Having the Hard Conversation

CORE THESIS: Empathizing isn't instead of setting boundaries — it's what earns you the right to have the hard conversation.

1. Timing: At the Timeout

WAIT FOR EMOTION TO DROP.

Don't correct mid-play. Wait until the heat is down so the message can actually land.

2. Ask Before You Tell

OPEN WITH A QUESTION.

"Can we talk about Friday?" keeps defenses down compared to opening with a verdict.

3. Offer Two Choices

HARVARD DEVELOPING CHILD TIP

Don't leave an open invite that evaporates. "Talk tonight or Saturday after breakfast?"

4. Name It Without Contempt

BOUNDARY VS. JUDGMENT

State the rule broken plainly without moral attacks ("What were you thinking?").

5. Hold Both Simultaneously

CONNECTION AND BOUNDARY

"I understand why you wanted to stay... AND curfew is still 10pm. Here's what's next."

6. Close Like a Coach

PROBLEM-SOLVING RETURN

"What will you do differently next time?" — invite them back into problem-solving, not just penalty.

FACILITATOR BRIDGE: "Empathizing earns the trust; this framework structures the follow-through so boundaries hold without rupture."

Structuring the Agreement: How to Reach Mutual Buy-In

THE MEDIATOR'S GOAL: Transition from enforcing rules to co-creating agreements. When teens help design the terms and consequences, compliance becomes shared ownership.

1. Build a Co-Created Plan

Design the agreement WITH your teen rather than handing down a unilateral mandate. Collaborative design fosters genuine accountability.

2. State Clear Non-Negotiables

Express essential safety rules plainly and objectively. Omit lectures, guilt trips, or moral judgments.

3. Invite Teen-Driven Solutions

Ask your teen to propose solutions and consequences first. Teens are often stricter on themselves and respect terms they own.

4. Establish Upfront Alignment

Ensure both parent and teen understand the rationale behind expectations and agree on consequences before problems happen.

5. Lock In Commitment & Future Focus

Seal the agreement with mutual respect. Keep the focus on future problem-solving rather than past mistakes.

Takeaway: Rules without relationship lead to rebellion; rules with relationship lead to respect.

Watch the Criticism — Gottman's Four Horsemen

THE FOUR COMMUNICATION BREAKDOWNS:

1. Criticism

Attacking character or core identity rather than specific behavior.

2. Defensiveness

Counter-attacking, making excuses, or playing the innocent victim.

3. Stonewalling

Withdrawing completely from interaction, tuning out, and building a wall.

4. Contempt

Disgust, sarcasm, mocking, or moral superiority — THE DEADLIEST HORSEMAN.

WHY CONTEMPT IS THE DEADLIEST

- **Conveys Disgust & Moral Superiority**

Contempt signals 'I am above you.' On the receiving end, a teen feels intense shame — which completely shuts them down rather than opening them up.

- **Predictor of Total Rupture**

In Gottman's research on married couples, contempt predicts divorce. In parent-child dynamics, it might predict complete relationship estrangement.

- **The 'Cut-Off' Generation**

College students and young adults today are quick to cut off parents entirely after repeated contempt. Reconnecting takes immense effort.

THE COACH'S ANTIDOTE:

Replace contempt with respectful observations. Describe how you feel and what you notice, not who they are.

PART 2 · REFLECTION

Reflection Moment: What's Underneath the Reaction

TAKE A MOMENT TO CONSIDER:

Think of a recent moment when your teen's independence triggered a strong reaction in you – anger, worry, irritation.

What might be underneath that reaction? (For you, not them).

- Turn to the person next to you and discuss. (Or share with the room).

CLOSING SUMMARY

Your Role Is the Coach, Not the Doer

✓ Give them enough room to try, enough space to get scraped up a bit, and get back up on their own.

✓ Maintain enough of a boundary to let them know you're still there to keep them safe — enough.

✓ Your job isn't to make them win every game.

✓ Your job is that by 18, they don't need you on the sideline anymore — because they have internalized your coaching voice as their own inner wisdom.

Hope is a plan you can practice, one play at a time.

NEXT STEPS & RESOURCES

One More Thing to Take Home

ACTION ITEM FOR THIS WEEK

- Print the 60-Second Reset and post it where your teen can see it.
- Make a visible show of using it yourself when you feel stressed.
- Modeling self-regulation speaks louder than lecturing about it.

WORKSHOP WEBSITE & CONTACT

Access all materials, the full Emotion Wheel, and citations on the passcode-protected workshop portal.

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KEEP GOING · MORE FROM THIS SERIES

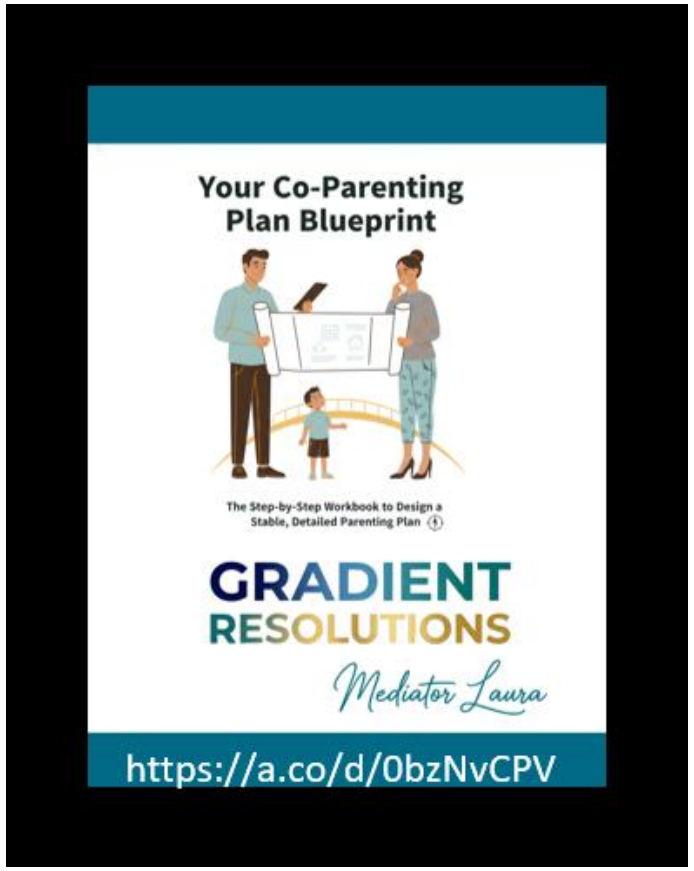
Two More Ways We Can Keep Working on This

UNDERSTANDING WHAT YOUR TEEN IS REALLY SAYING

- Explores how to adapt your parenting as your teen grows — the session you're in tonight.
- Covers the developmental framing, releasing control, and coaching skills from this workshop.
- Offered again — check GradientResolutions.com or the Poway Adult School catalog for the next date.

PERSONAL STRESS AND ANXIETY

- Build your own self-care so you can steady yourself — and help your kids through regulation and co-regulation.
- Monday, March 8, 2027 · 7:00–8:30pm.
- GradientResolutions.com or the Poway Adult School catalog for registration.



LET'S CONTINUE THE CONVERSATION

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LIVE

Know Your Kid's Temperament

Let's Chat!

Scan, or visit:

calendly.com/mediatorlaura/virtual-coffee-chat-clone

It's not about what's fair. It's about what's possible — for you and your kids.